Foundations of Chinese Intellectual History III

How Buddhism Became Chinese

The diffusion of Buddhism from India to China beginning in the first century of the Common Era was one of the most consequential cultural transmissions in history. Because Buddhism was not native to China, viewing Chinese Buddhism simply as a collection of divinities, rituals, and doctrines overlooks both the many challenges associated with its assimilation and the remarkable creativity both Buddhism and indigenous Chinese culture displayed in forging a uniquely *Chinese* Buddhism. Rather than viewing the tradition in purely historical or doctrinal terms, these lectures will look at a few of the larger and more persistent themes in Chinese Buddhism, focusing on the interaction with indigenous religious and philosophical traditions that came to make Chinese Buddhism a religious culture all its own.

Topics and Format

The course comprises six lectures, which can be attended either in sequence *or* as stand-alone presentations, enabling attendees to pick and choose the topics they are most interested in.

12 JANUARY — LECTURE ONE: BEYOND THE HINDU KUSH: ALEXANDER, THE SILK ROUTES, AND THE HELLENIZED STATES OF CENTRAL ASIA

Alexander's conquest of the Persian Achaemenid Empire in the last quarter of the fourth century BCE introduced Greek culture into the region and paved the way for a succession of Hellenized states in Central Asia. These states, sitting along the so-called Silk Routes connecting India, Persia, the Roman West, and China, became a crossroad reflecting influences from all these regions. It was through this area, comprising most of what is today northwest India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan, that Buddhism was first transmitted from its homeland to China, benefitting from the diversity of religious and philosophical thought in the Central Asian kingdoms through which it passed.

19 JANUARY — LECTURE TWO: HARMONIZING THE THREE TEACHINGS

Chinese culture was already at least sixteen centuries old, with a fully developed literature and world view, when Indian Buddhist texts first began to arrive in China. It is hard to imagine two more disparate cultures than those of India and China, and yet over a period of several centuries the Chinese absorbed, reflected upon, and transformed Indian Buddhism into a religious tradition of their own, introducing elements from Daoism and Confucianism into this foreign religion and accepting certain Indian religious concepts into their own culture. This blending was both uneven and irregular, but the resulting synthesis as a fully Chinese cultural product is encapsulated in the catchphrase *sanjiao heyi*, "the harmonization of the three teachings." Here we will look at this harmonization from a standpoint fundamental to both cultures: what does it mean to be a human being?

26 JANUARY LECTURE THREE: UNTANGLING THE KNOT

Buddhism was introduced to the Chinese piecemeal over several centuries by missionaries, traders, émigrés, and others, who brought with them from India and Central Asia a bewildering array of scriptures that in fact were the product of many different schools, time periods, and forms of Buddhism, not all of which were in agreement with each other (!) Knowing little of their provenance, and taking these scriptures at face value as the words of the Buddha himself, Chinese thinkers set about to reconcile the glaring differences they discerned in scripture by organizing them into systems representing different periods in the life of the Buddha or different levels of religious truth, depending on the spiritual maturity of his audience. These systematizations, however unfaithful to fact, played an important role in creating uniquely Chinese understandings of religious practice and are the embodiment of a distinctly Chinese attention to history and history writing.

2 FEBRUARY LECTURE FOUR: CHURCH AND STATE

Our own nation was founded in part to define the relationship between religious institutions and civil authority. This lecture will focus on a related problem in Chinese society: how Indian concepts of the special status of religious institutions, especially the privileged position of Buddhist clerics vis á vis the state, confronted and were altered by the very different Chinese notions of state authority. Are clergy exempt from obedience to the emperor? Does civil law take precedence over monastic regulations? Who controls the size and privileges of the clergy and their monasteries? To what exempt are church properties subject to taxation? Ultimately, who has the power?

9 FEBRUARY LECTURE FIVE: WAYS TO EMANCIPATION

Traditionally, Buddhism defined emancipation from the cycle of birth and death as the culmination of a lengthy cultivation of morality, meditation, and wisdom. But the Chinese, steeped as they were in Daoist notions of immanence and transcendence and by the sometimes contradictory doctrines they encountered in the texts transmitted from India, wondered, does enlightenment require a long process of religious cultivation or is it something achieved in a single, all-encompassing moment of insight? If we are all possessed of an innate, originally enlightened Buddha nature, of what value is a "search" for enlightenment? Why do we not *know* we're enlightened? Does the enlightenment experience admit of gradations? Debate over whether enlightenment was "sudden" or "gradual" or an amalgam of both was a persistent issue in Chinese Buddhism, receiving its most thoroughgoing treatment in debates within the Chan (Zen) tradition, where it resulted in new, uniquely Chinese forms of practice and religious discourse.

16 FEBRUARY LECTURE SIX: THE LATTER DAYS OF THE LAW

Such was the charisma of the Buddha that to be in his presence and to hear the Dharma preached by him was thought to be a powerful aid in bringing one to awakening. But what happens to those teachings when the Buddha is gone, when his words, like all worldly things, have fallen into decay and his salvific charisma is no longer available to suffering

beings? In China, awareness of the long time that had elapsed since the Buddha had been active in the world was experienced as an acute sense of loss, and many came to feel they were living in the "latter days of the law," a period when beings no longer had the capacity to attain emancipation through traditional practices. Out of this belief arose forms of practice that were deemed "easier" and more efficacious for the attainment of deliverance, among them faith in the salvific power of buddhas such as Amituofo (Amitābha) These came to be—and remain—the dominant form of practice among lay Buddhists in East Asia.

All classes will be held at the Heritage Center (Redding Community Center) at 10:30–11:45.

Classroom Materials

Download the classroom materials by clicking on this link or copying and pasting it into your browser: https://github.com/mcummingsny/Chinese-Buddhism

About the Instructor

Mark Cummings holds degrees in East Asian (MA, 1976) and religious studies (MA, 1978; MPhil, 1980) from Yale University and has taught courses in the religious traditions of South and East Asia at Hunter College in New York and Brown University. In 1982 he was hired by Macmillan Publishing Company to serve as the in-house editor and project manager for Asian philosophies and religions in *The Encyclopedia of Religion* (16 vols., 1987), leading to a professional career in reference and educational publishing. Since then, he has served, variously, as development editor for multivolume reference works at Oxford University Press, editor in chief of the *Encyclopedia Americana*, and vice president and publisher of the reference division at Scholastic Library Publishing.